Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 1 · DAYS 1-16

Creation and the Covenant of Works

Genesis 1-3

Who is God, and what is man? The foundations of all Christian doctrine.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

Creation psalms (8, 19:1-6, 29, 33:1-9, 65, and 104) answer Genesis 1 and 2 with praise.

UNIT 1

In this unit

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1	Genesis 1:1-2:3	*Reading*
2	2 Timothy 3:14-17; 2 Peter 1:16-21	*Doctrine*
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DAY 1 · WEEK 1

Genesis 1:1-2:3

God speaks creation into existence; the six days; the goodness of all things

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 1:1-2:3 slowly, and aloud if you can. It is the opening of the Bible and takes about five minutes. Notice the rhythm of the six days and the line that keeps returning: "And God saw that it was good." Read it once for the story, and once more asking what it tells you about God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Genesis is the first book of the Pentateuch, the five books of Moses, and was written for Israel as they prepared to enter the land God promised to Abraham. The original audience had just been delivered from slavery in Egypt, where they had lived for four hundred years under a culture full of competing gods: the sun, the river, the storm, and Pharaoh himself, who was called divine. Genesis 1 was a direct answer to all of that. It told them whose world they actually lived in.

This opening chapter is also the beginning of the entire biblical story, the foundation on which every covenant, every promise, and every redemptive act will rest. Before there can be a story of redemption, there must first be a creation worth redeeming. Before there can be a Savior, there must first be a Creator. Genesis 1 tells us who God is, what kind of world he made, and what humanity was made for. Everything that follows in Scripture depends on getting this beginning right.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The chapter follows a clear pattern: "And God said… and it was so… and God saw that it was good." Notice how often this rhythm repeats. Counting them is itself an act of observation.

2. There is a parallel structure between the days. Days 1-3 form realms (light/dark, sky/sea, land/vegetation), and Days 4-6 fill those realms with their inhabitants (sun and moon, fish and birds, animals and humans). Creation is ordered, not chaotic.
3. God speaks. He does not struggle, fight, or shape creation out of pre-existing material that opposes him. He commands, and reality obeys.
4. The creation of humanity is set apart. There is a divine deliberation ("Let us make man in our image"), a doubling of the verb "created" in verse 27, and the explicit blessing and commission given to no other creature.
5. The seventh day is the climax, not the sixth. The creation of humanity is the high point of the work, but the Sabbath is the high point of the week.
6. The phrase "it was good" appears seven times. After humanity is made, it becomes "very good." Goodness is woven into the fabric of what God has made.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 1 is not primarily concerned with how God created or how long it took. Its concern is who God is, what he made, and what kind of world we live in. Every other ancient creation story in the world that Israel encountered, Babylonian, Egyptian, Canaanite, featured gods who fought, struggled, killed one another, or formed the world out of corpses and chaos. Genesis 1 stands utterly apart. There is one God. He is sovereign over all things. He creates by speaking, not by struggling. And what he makes is good.

The opening verse establishes everything: "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth." Before there was time, there was God. Before there was matter, there was God. He is not part of the created order; he is its source. The Hebrew word for "created" here is bara, a verb used only of God, never of human making. It signals something only God can do: bring into existence what was not there before.

Then comes the pattern. God speaks, and what he says becomes reality. Light comes into being at his word. Land separates from sea at his word. Plants grow, stars appear, creatures swim and fly and walk, all at his word. This is the doctrine of creation by divine speech, and it carries enormous theological weight. It means God's word is not advisory or decorative; it is creative. What God says, is. When you later read that the gospel comes to you "through the word," or that you are "born again by the imperishable seed of the word," remember that the same word that called galaxies into existence is now calling sinners into new life.

The chapter unfolds in a deliberate, beautiful symmetry. Days 1, 2, and 3 form realms, God separates light from darkness, waters above from waters below, and dry land from sea. Days 4, 5, and 6 fill those realms, sun and moon for day and night, birds and fish for sky and sea,

animals and humans for the land. The world is not random. It is shaped, ordered, and prepared like a home being made ready for its inhabitants. And the chief inhabitant for whom the home is prepared is humanity.

When the sixth day arrives, the pattern shifts. God deliberates: “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.” The plural is striking, Christian readers have long seen here the first hint of the triune nature of God, though the doctrine of the Trinity is not yet articulated. What is articulated is that humanity is unique. Of every other creature, God said “Let the earth bring forth” or “Let the waters swarm.” But of humanity, God said “Let us make.” Humanity bears God’s image, male and female together, blessed, commissioned, and given responsibility over creation. This is the foundation of all Christian anthropology. Every human you will ever meet bears the image of God.

And then, on the seventh day, God rests. Not because he is tired. He rests because the work is finished, and rest is the goal of the work. The Sabbath is woven into the fabric of creation before any law is given. It tells us that the universe has a purpose, and that purpose is not endless production but communion with God in restful joy. Every Sabbath the church gathers, every Lord’s Day a believer enters worship, points back to this seventh day, and forward to the eternal rest that awaits the people of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Day 1 is the foundation. There is no previous reading to build on, but everything that follows in this plan will build on this. The God who speaks here is the same God who will call Abraham, deliver Israel from Egypt, give the law at Sinai, raise up David, send his Son, and pour out his Spirit. The world he makes here is the same world that will be cursed in Genesis 3, redeemed at the cross, and renewed in the new heavens and new earth. Watch how often the rest of Scripture echoes this chapter: John’s Gospel opens “In the beginning was the Word,” directly mirroring Genesis 1:1. Revelation closes with a new creation that fulfills what began here. The whole Bible is in some sense the story of how God brings his good creation to its appointed rest in Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Begin where Scripture begins: with God as Creator. This is not a doctrine you accept once and move past. It is the lens through which you see everything else. Because God made you, you have inherent dignity that no one can give and no one can take. Because God made your body, your body is not a prison or an accident, it is good. Because God made the world, your

work in the world matters; gardening, parenting, building, studying, serving are all forms of carrying out the mandate given to humanity in the image of God. Because God made the Sabbath, your rest is not laziness but worship.

Today, consider one practical response: where in your life have you been treating something God made as either worthless or as ultimate? The created order points beyond itself to its Creator. Eat your food with gratitude. Take in a sunset and let it lead you to praise. Treat the people around you as image-bearers worthy of dignity. And when you grow tired, let your weariness remind you that the goal of creation is not endless work but the rest of God himself, a rest finally fulfilled in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as Creator, and thank him for one thing in your life you have received as a gift from his hand.
- Ask him to open your eyes to see his goodness in ordinary things today.
- Tell him what you want to learn about him as you begin this journey.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 2 · WEEK 1

2 Timothy 3:14-17; 2 Peter 1:16-21

The Doctrine of Scripture (Bibliology)

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Timothy 3:14-17 and 2 Peter 1:16-21 prayerfully. These are the two most direct New Testament passages on what Scripture is and where it comes from. Read each twice, slowly. Notice how Paul speaks of Scripture, and notice how Peter speaks of the prophetic writings. Read aloud if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Today is the first doctrinal pause day in the plan. Throughout these two years, the regular flow of reading will be interrupted occasionally by a day devoted to articulating a major Christian doctrine, not because doctrine is separate from Scripture, but because Scripture itself teaches doctrine and asks us to think clearly about it. These days take a short passage of Scripture as the anchor and explore the teaching that emerges from it.

Before going further in this plan, we need to settle a foundational question: why trust this book? Yesterday you read Genesis 1, and across the next two years you will read every other book of the Bible. But every word of every reading rests on a prior conviction, that the Bible is not merely a human collection of religious literature, but the very word of God to humanity. The two passages you just read are where the Bible most directly tells us what it is and where it came from. Before we read anything else, we need to know what we are reading.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Paul tells Timothy that he has known the “sacred writings” from childhood, these were the Old Testament Scriptures. Paul assumes the OT is Scripture.
2. The phrase “breathed out by God” (theopneustos in Greek) is striking. Scripture is not just inspired in the way poets are “inspired”; it is the very breath of God in written

form.

3. Scripture is described as "profitable" for four things: teaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness. It both informs and forms.

4. The goal of Scripture is the maturity and equipping of the man of God, "complete, equipped for every good work." Scripture is sufficient.

5. Peter writes that the gospel message is not "cleverly devised myths." He claims eyewitness authority and points to the prophetic word as "more fully confirmed."

6. The famous phrase "men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" uses a sailing metaphor, the human authors were genuinely active, but the Spirit determined the direction.

7. Both passages root Scripture's authority in God himself, not in human committees, religious institutions, or personal experience.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The doctrine of Scripture, sometimes called bibliology, is the foundation of every other Christian doctrine. If we cannot trust this book, we have nothing to say about God, sin, salvation, the church, or the future. So the first question is the most important: what is the Bible?

The Bible's own answer is that it is the inspired Word of God. The Greek word Paul uses, theopneustos, does not mean that God's people came up with religious ideas and God endorsed them. It means that Scripture is breathed out by God himself. The human authors wrote real letters, with their own vocabularies, personalities, and circumstances, but what they wrote, God wrote. Peter's image of being "carried along" by the Spirit (the same word used of a ship driven by the wind) captures the same point: God's authorship works in and through human authorship, not around it.

From this doctrine of inspiration flows four other claims the church has historically made about Scripture.

First, inerrancy. Because Scripture is breathed out by God, and because God cannot lie or be mistaken, Scripture in its original form does not err. This does not mean every translation is perfect, or that every word must be read with a flat literalism. It means that when properly understood, Scripture does not lead us into falsehood. What God teaches in his Word is true.

Second, authority. Because Scripture is God's Word, it has the authority God has. To submit to Scripture is to submit to God; to dismiss Scripture is to dismiss God. The Bible is not one voice among many that the Christian considers; it is the voice to which all other voices are

accountable.

Third, sufficiency. Paul says Scripture is enough, that through it the believer becomes "complete, equipped for every good work." Christians do not need new revelations, secret traditions, or extra-biblical mystical experiences to know what God requires of them. Scripture contains all that is necessary for salvation, faith, and life.

Fourth, clarity (or perspicuity). The Bible is not so obscure that only the highly trained can understand it. The main message, who God is, what humanity has done, what Christ has accomplished, how we are saved, is clear enough that an ordinary believer reading prayerfully can grasp it. This does not mean every passage is easy. It means the gospel is not hidden.

A few common misunderstandings deserve mention. Inspiration does not mean dictation, as if the human authors were typewriters and God pressed the keys. The authors' personalities and styles are visible everywhere. Authority does not mean the church's authority over Scripture, but Scripture's authority over the church. Sufficiency does not rule out the use of pastors, teachers, study aids, or tradition, it rules out treating any of those as equal to Scripture. And inerrancy applies to what Scripture teaches, not to incidental matters about which it makes no claim.

When we approach the Bible, we approach the voice of God himself. That is why every study of the faith begins here, and why every Christian's life of discipleship is sustained, by the regular, prayerful reading of Scripture.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The two passages you read make claims about Scripture that nothing else in the world makes about itself. Paul calls the Bible the breath of God. Peter says its writers were carried along by the Holy Spirit. These are not modest claims, and they have shaped Christianity from the beginning.

Consider Paul's words to Timothy first. Paul is writing to a young pastor who is facing opposition, false teaching, and discouragement. What does Paul tell him to rely on? Not his own giftedness, not his connections, not even Paul's continued mentorship, but the Scriptures he has known from childhood. Why? Because they are "able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus." This is a remarkable statement. Paul does not say Scripture is one tool among many; he says it has the power to bring a person to saving wisdom. The Bible does what no other book does. It carries the breath of God.

Peter's testimony adds a different angle. He is writing as someone who has seen the transfiguration with his own eyes. He could appeal to his apostolic eyewitness, and he does. But then he says something stunning: we have the prophetic word "more fully confirmed." More confirmed than his own eyewitness experience. Why? Because Peter knows that even his experience must be tested by Scripture, not the other way around. He calls Scripture "a lamp shining in a dark place." Not a lamp that helps a bit, but the lamp by which we navigate the darkness of this age.

This is the posture every Christian must take toward the Bible. The world we live in is full of competing voices, cultural assumptions, personal feelings, political loyalties, religious traditions. None of these is wholly absent from a Christian's life, and not all of them are bad. But none of them is the voice of God. When they speak against Scripture, they are wrong. When they align with Scripture, it is Scripture that gives them their weight. The Bible is the lamp; everything else gets its light from it.

This is also why the regular reading of Scripture is not an optional Christian habit. It is the way the breath of God reaches you. Through this book, the Spirit who carried the writers along still carries the readers along, into greater knowledge of Christ, into deeper repentance, into more mature obedience. You will not grow as a Christian apart from this book. And you do not need any other book to grow. Whatever else might be helpful, and many things are, the Bible is sufficient. The God who breathed out these words breathes them into your soul as you read them.

The implication is enormous. This is not a museum piece, not an inspirational anthology, not a religious classic. This is God speaking. When you open Scripture, the same God who said "Let there be light" is speaking to you, and what he says, taught, reproved, corrected, trained, is meant to make you complete. Approach it accordingly.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday you read Genesis 1, where God created by speaking. The doctrine of Scripture takes that same divine speech and tells us that what God has breathed out is not only the heavens and the earth, but also this written word. The God of Genesis 1, who spoke worlds into being, is the same God who has spoken in Scripture, and as you keep reading, you will hear his voice through every page. Every reading after today rests on what was settled here: this book is the breath of God, sufficient and authoritative, the lamp that lights our way through the entire story of redemption you are about to read.

STEP 6

Application

Trust this book. That is the practical heart of today's doctrine. Trust it when it speaks comfortably to you, and trust it when it confronts you. Trust it when it agrees with your culture, and trust it when it contradicts your culture. Trust it when it confirms what you already wanted to believe, and trust it especially when it tells you something you did not want to hear. The Bible is the breath of God; treat it as such.

Practically, this means three things. First, ask whether Scripture holds first place in your days. What would it look like for hearing God to become a habit and not a project? Second, when Scripture and your feelings disagree, trust Scripture. Feelings are real but unreliable; God's Word is reliable. Third, when teachers or churches contradict Scripture, trust Scripture. The Bible is not under any earthly authority. It is the authority over them.

There is one more practical implication: do not be afraid to read this book. Yes, it has hard parts. Yes, it asks more of you than you can give. But it was written to be understood by ordinary believers under the guidance of the Spirit. Read it humbly. Pray before you read. Read with the church when you can. And expect God to speak. He does, every time.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has spoken, and that you are not left to guess who he is.
- Confess any place where you have trusted your own judgment over what Scripture says.
- Ask him for a humble, hungry heart toward his Word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 3 · WEEK 1

Genesis 2:4-25

The garden, the man, the woman; the covenant of works arranged

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Reading · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 2:4-25 slowly. Genesis 1 gave a wide view of creation; this chapter zooms in on the garden, the man, and the woman. Notice what God provides, what he commands, and the one thing he calls “not good.” Read it aloud if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Genesis 2 is not a second, contradictory creation story. It is a deliberate narrowing, a re-telling that zooms in on Day 6 of Chapter 1 to show us how humanity, in particular, was made and where humanity was placed. In Hebrew literary form, this kind of telescoping is common: first a wide overview, then a closer look at the part that matters most for the story to follow.

What follows in the Bible, the Fall, the covenants, the long history of redemption, only makes sense if we understand what humanity was originally meant to be and where humanity was originally meant to live. Genesis 2 sets up the covenant relationship between God and Adam that the next chapter will catastrophically break.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The name “LORD God” (Yahweh Elohim) appears here for the first time. Genesis 1 used Elohim, the general word for God. Now we encounter God’s covenant name combined with that title, the same God, but now revealed in personal relationship.
2. God forms man from the dust and breathes into his nostrils. Humanity is both earthly (made of the same material as the ground) and uniquely alive with God’s own breath.
3. The garden is described in beautiful detail, trees pleasant to the sight and good for food, a river that divides into four headwaters. This is paradise, but it is also a real place.

4. There are two named trees: the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. The command not to eat from the second is the first command God gives to humanity.

5. Adam is told to "work and keep" the garden. These same two Hebrew verbs are later used of the priests' service in the Tabernacle. Adam is, in a sense, the first priest.

6. The making of the woman is preceded by Adam discovering that nothing in creation corresponds to him. The woman is made from his side, not from his head to rule him or his feet to be ruled, but from his side as his equal partner.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 2 reveals that the creation account is, at its heart, a covenant account. The setting is a garden, Eden, but the garden is more than a beautiful place. It is the temple of creation, the meeting place between God and humanity, the original holy ground. The river that flows out of it waters the world, suggesting that what happens in this garden is meant to spread outward, that the holiness and life of God's presence is meant to extend to the ends of the earth.

Into this garden God places the man, and the words used to describe his task are loaded. He is to "work" and "keep" it, the same words later used of the priests who served in the Tabernacle. Adam is given a role that is simultaneously royal (exercising dominion) and priestly (serving and guarding the sacred space). He is a king-priest in a garden-temple, representing God to creation and creation to God.

Then comes the command. "Of every tree of the garden you may surely eat, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die." Notice the structure: God's generosity comes first ("of every tree… you may surely eat") and the one prohibition follows. This is the pattern of all true covenant relationship with God. Grace and gift come first; obedience is the response. The single commandment is not God being stingy or cruel. It is the test of whether Adam will trust God's wisdom about good and evil, or whether he will reach out and try to define those things for himself.

This arrangement is what theologians have long called the covenant of works. God offered Adam a relationship of life and blessing on the condition of obedience. Had Adam obeyed, he would have come into the fullness of what God offered, life confirmed, blessing extended, perhaps eventually access to the tree of life itself. But the conditional nature of the arrangement also meant that disobedience would bring death. The stakes were not arbitrary; they were the natural consequence of either trusting God or refusing to.

Then the narrative slows down again. God observes that "it is not good that the man should be alone." This is the first thing in creation declared not good, and it is not a flaw in creation, but a deliberate setup. Adam needs to discover his own lack before he receives the gift of a partner. So God brings the animals, and Adam names them, exercising his dominion, but also noticing that none of them correspond to him. None is a true partner.

So God puts Adam into a deep sleep, takes a rib from his side, and forms the woman. Adam's response is the first poetry in the Bible: "This at last is bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh." Marriage is established before the Fall, before sin enters the world. It is part of God's original good design, a covenant between a man and a woman that pictures, in its own way, the deeper covenant between God and his people. The chapter ends with the haunting line: "And the man and his wife were both naked and were not ashamed." There was no fear, no hiding, no covering. That is the world we lost.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday we saw God speak the cosmos into existence. Today we see him stoop to the dust and form a man with his own hands. The same God who is transcendent over creation is also intimate with his creatures. This is the God whose Son will later "take on flesh and dwell among us," who will gather children in his arms, who will form a new humanity from his pierced side as Adam's bride was formed from his. The pattern of Genesis 2, a man, a garden, a tree, a bride, will echo throughout Scripture all the way to the new creation in Revelation 22, where the tree of life appears again, and the river flows again, and the bride of Christ is finally united to her husband forever.

STEP 6

Application

If you are tempted today to think God is distant or impersonal, return to Genesis 2. The God of the Bible is not aloof. He kneels in the dust to form humanity. He plants a garden by hand. He breathes his own life into Adam's nostrils. He notices when his creature is alone and provides for him. This is the kind of God you serve.

Practically, consider three things today. First, your body is not a problem, it is part of God's design, formed by God himself. Treat it as such. Second, work is not a curse from the Fall; it was given before sin entered. The work you do this week is part of God's image-bearing commission. Do it well. Third, the relationships God has given you, spouse, family, friends, church, are reflections of the original "it is not good for man to be alone." You were not made for isolation. Show up. Be present. Let the people God has put in your life see your face without shame, as far as it is possible.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making you a creature with a body, a place, and relationships, and tell him if any of that is hard to receive as a gift.

Ask him to show you what he has placed in your care.

Speak to him about any place where you are tempted to doubt his good word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 4 · WEEK 1

Genesis 1:26-28; Genesis 9:6; James 3:9

The Image of God

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 1:26-28, Genesis 9:6, and James 3:9 prayerfully. These three passages are short, but they are the foundation of everything the Bible says about being human. Read them aloud if you can. Notice how each one applies the doctrine of the image of God to a different situation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two days ago you read Genesis 1, where God made humanity in his image. Yesterday's doctrinal day set the foundation of Scripture itself. Today we take the central claim of Genesis 1, that humanity is the image of God, and explore what it actually means. This is the most important question any human being can ask: what am I, and why does my existence matter? The Christian answer is not that humans are slightly evolved animals, or accidentally meaningful collections of atoms, or self-defining beings free to invent their own purpose. The Christian answer is that every human being bears the image of God, and that this image carries with it dignity, vocation, and destiny.

The three short passages you read today show this doctrine applied in three different ways: as the source of human dignity at creation, as the basis for the sanctity of life after the flood, and as the reason ordinary speech matters in everyday Christian behavior. The doctrine is not abstract; it presses on every part of human existence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 1:26 uses a plural, "Let us make man in our image", which Christians have long seen as a hint of the triune nature of God.

2. The image of God is given to humanity as male and female together, not to one sex alone. Both fully bear the image.
3. The image is connected immediately to a commission: "be fruitful and multiply… have dominion." Image-bearing is not just a status; it is a vocation.
4. Genesis 9:6 grounds the prohibition against murder in the image of God. To take a human life is to assault the One whose image that life bears.
5. James 3:9 applies the image of God to speech, cursing other people is incompatible with worshiping God, because those people bear God's image.
6. Across all three passages, the image of God is never said to be partial or lost. Even fallen humans, even violent humans, even people we are tempted to curse, still bear it.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The doctrine of the image of God, what theologians call the imago Dei, is one of Christianity's most distinctive contributions to human thought. Every Christian doctrine about humanity begins here. To answer the question "what is a human being?" Christians answer: a creature made in the image of God.

But what does that mean? Theologians have offered three main approaches that emphasize different aspects of the biblical witness.

The first is the substantive view, which says the image consists in some quality humans share with God, rationality, moral capacity, self-awareness, a soul, the ability to know God. There is something to this. Humans are unlike other creatures in their capacity for abstract thought, moral reflection, language, and worship.

The second is the relational view, which emphasizes that humans were made for relationship, with God, with one another, with creation itself. We image God not just in what we are, but in how we relate. The fact that Genesis 1 says we were made "male and female" right alongside the image language supports this. The Trinity itself is eternal relationship, and image-bearers are made for relationship too.

The third is the functional view, which highlights the immediate commission given in Genesis 1: dominion over creation. In the ancient Near East, kings were sometimes called the "image" of their gods, meaning the king represented the god's rule on earth. Humanity, plural and equal, is given that role. We are not gods, but we are God's image-bearers, his representatives in the world he made.

The fullest understanding includes all three. We image God in our being (rationality, morality, capacity for worship), in our relating (to God, to one another), and in our doing (representing his rule in creation). The image is not one thing; it is the whole shape of what it means to be human.

A critical implication: the image of God was damaged but not destroyed by the Fall. Genesis 9, written after the Fall, still grounds the value of human life in the image of God. James, written to Christians, still calls fellow humans image-bearers. Sin distorts the image; it does not erase it. Every human being you will ever meet, your closest friend, your worst enemy, the unborn child, the elderly grandmother with dementia, the criminal, the saint, the stranger you will never know, bears the image of God. This is the ground of universal human dignity.

But there is more. The New Testament reveals that the image of God is most fully expressed not in fallen Adam, but in Christ. Paul calls Jesus "the image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:15). Christ is what we were meant to be, the true human, the second Adam. And through union with Christ, believers are being "transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another" (2 Corinthians 3:18). Sanctification is the restoration of the image. Heaven is the image fully restored.

So when you ask "what am I?" the Christian answer comes in three tenses. You were made in God's image. That image was marred in the Fall. And in Christ, that image is being restored, and one day will be perfectly fulfilled in glory.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages you read show the doctrine of the image of God doing actual work in Scripture. None of them stops at "humans are special." Each one draws an ethical conclusion from the doctrine.

Genesis 1:26-28 sets the foundation. Notice the structure: God deliberates ("Let us make"), God acts ("So God created"), and God commissions ("Be fruitful… have dominion"). Image-bearing is not a passive identity; it is a calling. To be made in God's image is to be tasked with reflecting God's rule in the world. Marriage, family, work, creativity, stewardship of the earth, all of these flow from this opening commission. When you raise children, build something, grow a garden, organize a project, or care for a place, you are doing image-bearing work.

Genesis 9:6 takes the doctrine into the most extreme ethical territory: the taking of human life. Right after the flood, as humanity begins again, God establishes the boundary that protects human life: "Whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed, for

God made man in his own image." The reason given is theological, not pragmatic. Murder is not just a social problem or a personal tragedy. It is an attack on the image of God himself. This is why every human life, regardless of usefulness, age, ability, or status, carries an irreducible weight. To diminish a human being is to insult the One whose image that human bears.

James 3:9 brings the doctrine right into ordinary life: how you talk. "With it we bless our Lord and Father, and with it we curse people who are made in the likeness of God." James sees a contradiction, and notice what he calls the contradiction. Not that we are inconsistent in our speech, or hypocritical, though those things are true. The contradiction is that the same God we praise has made the people we curse in his own likeness. You cannot worship God on Sunday and despise your spouse, coworker, neighbor, or political opponent on Monday. They bear the image of the One you claim to worship. Image-bearing makes every encounter with a human being an encounter with the dignity of God himself.

This is why Christianity has, throughout history, been the source of the strongest claims about universal human dignity. Not because Christians have always lived consistently, they haven't, but because the doctrine forces the issue. If every human bears the image of God, then slavery is wrong, infanticide is wrong, racism is wrong, abuse is wrong, neglect of the poor is wrong. Not wrong because we feel they are, but wrong because God has put his image in every person, and you cannot trample on that image without trampling on God himself.

The doctrine also means something about you. You are not nothing. You are not a mistake. You are not less than anyone. The God who made the stars made you in his image, called you good, and gave you a calling to image him in the world. Whatever lies you have believed about your worth, whether from yourself or from others, Genesis 1 outranks all of them.

STEP 5

Connection

In Genesis 1 the image of God was given. In Genesis 3 (which you read yesterday) that image was marred, humans began to image themselves as gods rather than to image the true God. But the image was not lost. Every page that follows in the Bible assumes humans still bear it: that is why Cain's murder of Abel matters in Genesis 4, why the law protects the dignity of every Israelite, why the prophets thunder against the abuse of the poor. And the whole story climaxes in Christ, the perfect image of God in human form. Through union with him, the image in us is being restored. The doctrine of the image of God runs from Genesis 1 to the new creation, where image-bearers will reign with Christ over the renewed earth, finally being what we were always meant to be.

STEP 6

Application

Treat people as image-bearers. That is the daily, practical heart of this doctrine. The cashier at the store, the driver who cut you off, your spouse on a hard day, the colleague you disagree with, the family member who has hurt you, the stranger on the corner asking for change, each of them bears the image of the same God you worship. You cannot honor God while dishonoring his image.

This works two directions. It calls you to higher respect for others than the world's standards of usefulness or attractiveness or moral worth would suggest. And it calls you to higher respect for yourself than your own self-loathing might allow. You are an image-bearer. So are they. The doctrine permits neither contempt of others nor self-contempt.

Today, identify one person in your life who is hard for you to honor. It might be someone who has wronged you, someone you find irritating, someone you have written off, or someone you simply do not notice. Think of that person as one who bears the image of God. Pray for them. Speak kindly of them, or at least refuse to speak cruelly. And ask the Spirit to keep forming Christ, the true image of God, in you, so that one day your imaging of God will be as true and as full as his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you were made in his image, and tell him where you struggle to believe it about yourself.

Ask him to show you someone you have treated as less than an image bearer, and to change how you see them.

Praise Jesus as the perfect image of the Father.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 5 · WEEK 1

Genesis 3:1-24

Temptation, the Fall, the curse, and the first gospel promise

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 3:1-24 slowly, and aloud if you can. This is the saddest chapter in the Bible and the most important for understanding everything that follows. Notice what the serpent asks, how Adam and Eve respond, and how God appears in the story, both in judgment and in promise (look closely at verse 15).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we saw the world as it was meant to be: a garden, a man, a woman, work and rest, presence and partnership, no shame. Today everything changes. Genesis 3 is the story of how the very good creation of chapters 1 and 2 was broken. But more than that, it is the chapter that explains every news headline, every funeral, every estrangement, every disease, every disordered desire you have ever experienced. The whole biblical story of redemption assumes Genesis 3. Without this chapter, the gospel makes no sense, because without this chapter, there is nothing for the gospel to fix.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The serpent does not begin with a direct contradiction. He begins with a question: “Did God actually say…?” Doubt is planted before disobedience.
2. Eve’s response slightly distorts God’s command, she adds “neither shall you touch it.” The slightest drift from God’s actual word makes further drift easier.
3. The serpent finally contradicts God directly: “You will not surely die.” He then accuses God of withholding something good, “you will be like God.”
4. The order of the temptation is striking: the woman saw that the tree was good for food (the appetite), a delight to the eyes (the senses), and to be desired to make one wise (the

mind). 1 John 2:16 echoes this triad.

5. Adam was "with her." He was not deceived in the same way; he failed in passive silence.
6. Their first response to sin is shame, they suddenly know they are naked and try to cover themselves. Their second is hiding from God. Their third is blame, Adam blames the woman (and implicitly God for giving her), the woman blames the serpent.
7. Verse 15 is the first gospel promise: the offspring of the woman will crush the serpent's head. Before any curse is even spoken to humanity, a promise of victory is given.
8. God himself clothes them with garments of skin, the first death in Scripture is an animal slain to cover human shame.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 3 is the most consequential chapter in the entire Old Testament. Everything in human experience that you grieve, every relational wound, every body that breaks down, every system that goes wrong, finds its origin here. And yet, before the chapter ends, the gospel has already been promised. This is both the worst news in Scripture and the moment when the best news begins.

The temptation is subtle. The serpent does not roar in declaring God a liar; he whispers a question. "Did God actually say...?" Doubt always precedes rebellion. Notice what is being attacked: not God's existence, not even God's power, but God's word. If God's word cannot be trusted, if it is unclear, or stingy, or designed to keep us from something better, then disobedience starts to feel reasonable. The serpent's whole strategy is to make God seem less generous than he is. He frames God's one prohibition as if it were God's whole posture: "Did God actually say you shall not eat of any tree?" But God had said the opposite, eat of every tree, except this one. Generosity comes first, prohibition is the exception. The serpent inverts it.

Eve's response begins well but slips. She defends God's generosity, but then she adds something God never said: "neither shall you touch it." It is a small drift, but every great failure begins with a small drift from God's actual word. The serpent then makes his move. He flatly contradicts God ("you will not surely die") and slanders God's motives ("God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil"). The accusation is that God is holding out on them, that obedience keeps them from their true potential.

And here is the heart of all sin: the desire to define good and evil for ourselves, to be like God on our own terms. Eve's eyes go to the fruit. It is good for food, pleasing to look at, and seems to offer wisdom. Three categories of desire are activated, appetite, beauty, ambition, and she

takes. The Hebrew word translated “took” is the same word later used for taking another man’s wife or seizing what is not yours. It is the language of theft. And Adam, who has been “with her” through the whole exchange, takes too, in silence.

What happens next is the world we now live in. Their eyes are opened, but not to be like God. They are opened to shame. They cover themselves with leaves. They hide from God when he comes walking in the garden. When God confronts them, they blame, Adam blames Eve, and implicitly God himself (“the woman whom you gave to be with me”); Eve blames the serpent. Sin always fractures relationships. With God, with each other, with creation itself.

Then come the curses. The serpent is cursed first. The woman’s pain in childbearing and her relationship with her husband are disordered. The man’s work, once a joy, will now be filled with thorns and sweat. And finally death, “to dust you shall return.” The full weight of God’s earlier warning falls. But there, in the middle of the cursing of the serpent, comes verse 15: “I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.” This is the protoevangelium, the first gospel. Before any judgment is pronounced on humans, before any human is sent out of the garden, a promise has already been made: a son of the woman will one day come and crush the serpent’s head. The cost will be real, the serpent will bruise his heel. But the victory belongs to the woman’s offspring.

And then, in a quiet act of mercy, God makes garments of skin and clothes Adam and Eve. Animals die to cover human shame, the first hint of a sacrificial principle that will run through the entire Bible, all the way to a cross where the Lamb of God will bear the sin of the world.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday’s covenant of works has been broken. The man and woman who were placed in the garden as priest-king and partner have failed the test, and the consequences fall on themselves, their children, and the creation entrusted to them. But the story does not end with the curse. Genesis 3:15 is the seed from which every later promise grows, the promised offspring of Abraham, the suffering servant of Isaiah, the son of David, the Word made flesh. When Romans 16:20 says God will “soon crush Satan under your feet,” it is echoing Genesis 3:15. When Christ on the cross declares “It is finished,” he is fulfilling Genesis 3:15. The whole Bible is the unfolding of the promise made in this chapter, that the seed of the woman would do what Adam failed to do, and would crush the head of the one who deceived humanity.

STEP 6

Application

Look at the serpent's strategy and recognize it, because it is still in use today. "Did God actually say…?" The accusation that God is withholding something good. The framing of obedience as oppression and disobedience as liberation. These are the same temptations you will face this week, this year, your whole life. The defense is not stronger willpower. The defense is a settled trust in God's word and God's character. The serpent could not have succeeded if Eve had said: "Whatever God said, he said because he is good. I do not need to be like God; I am made by God, and that is enough."

Today, consider one place in your life where you are tempted to think God is holding out on you. Maybe it is a desire you are being asked to wait on or set aside. Maybe it is a command that feels restrictive. Bring it before God honestly. And then remember that the very God who gave that command is the God who, in this same chapter, made the first promise of a Savior, and who, in the fullness of time, sent his only Son to crush the serpent and clothe sinners not in leaves but in his own righteousness. Your trust in God's word and your trust in God's love are not separable. Trust both today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess in your own words where you have listened to the serpent's doubt about God's word or goodness.

Thank God for the promise of the one who would crush the serpent, and tell him what that means to you.

Ask him to clothe you in Christ rather than in your own coverings.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 6 · WEEK 1

Genesis 3:1-24; Romans 5:12-21

The Doctrine of Sin (Hamartiology)

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Re-read Genesis 3:1-24, yesterday's passage, and then read Romans 5:12-21. These two passages together form the backbone of the Christian doctrine of sin. Genesis tells the story; Romans tells you what the story means. Read slowly, especially the Romans passage, which is one of the densest in the New Testament.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you read the Fall in Genesis 3, the narrative of how sin entered the world. Today we step back to ask the larger question: what exactly happened, and what does it mean for every human being who has ever lived? This is the doctrine of sin, sometimes called hamartiology.

The doctrine of sin is the most empirically verifiable doctrine in all of Christianity. You see its effects every day, in yourself and in everyone you know. The problem is not knowing whether something is wrong with humanity. The problem is understanding what is wrong, how deep it goes, and what can be done about it. Genesis 3 and Romans 5 give us the answer. Today we explore what they teach.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Romans 5:12 traces sin and death back to one man: "sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin." The doctrine of original sin is not invented; it is taught.
2. Notice the parallel Paul builds: "as by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous" (5:19). Adam and Christ stand opposite each other.

3. Death is described as reigning "from Adam to Moses, even over those whose sinning was not like the transgression of Adam." Death affects even those who did not personally break a specific command.

4. The Greek word for "sin" (hamartia) means "missing the mark", failing to be or do what God made us to be and do.

5. Genesis 3 shows sin entering through doubt of God's word, distrust of God's character, and the desire to define good and evil for oneself.

6. The first effect of sin is shame and hiding. The image-bearers who walked with God now flee from him.

7. Sin's consequences ripple outward: from the relationship with God (alienation), to the marriage relationship (blame), to the body (death), to the ground itself (cursed).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Christian doctrine of sin makes four claims that distinguish it from every other diagnosis of the human condition.

First, sin is universal. Every human being, without exception (Christ alone excepted), is a sinner. This is not a claim about culture or upbringing or environment. It is a claim about human nature itself, since the Fall. "All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (Romans 3:23). You did not choose to become a sinner; you were born one. Even before you committed your first conscious act of disobedience, you were already inheriting the corrupted nature passed down from Adam.

Second, sin is deep. The traditional name for this is "total depravity," and the term is often misunderstood. It does not mean every human is as evil as they could possibly be, clearly people are capable of impressive virtues, kindnesses, and acts of love. What it means is that sin has touched every part of human existence, the mind, the will, the affections, the body, the conscience. There is no part of you that is untainted, no morally neutral zone that sin has not penetrated. This is why Paul says even our good works, apart from Christ, are insufficient. Sin runs all the way down.

Third, sin is inherited. This is the doctrine of original sin. When Adam fell, he did not fall as a private individual but as the federal head of humanity, the representative in whom all his descendants are reckoned. Paul makes this explicit in Romans 5: through Adam, sin and death spread to all. This is why babies die, why every culture in every era produces both wonders and atrocities, why your own heart deceives even you. The corruption did not start with you; it was waiting for you the moment you were conceived.

Fourth, sin is offensive to God. This is what makes sin sin and not merely failure or error. Sin is a moral assault on the holiness of God. It is treason against the rightful Lord of creation. It deserves judgment, not just because God is angry, but because God is just. A holy God cannot be indifferent to sin without ceasing to be holy.

These four claims paint a picture darker than most modern people are comfortable with. But notice what they make possible. If sin is universal, no one can save themselves by being a better person, and so no one is left behind, every human equally needs grace. If sin is deep, surface-level moralism cannot fix us, and so the gospel offers a new heart, not a self-improvement program. If sin is inherited, salvation must also be inherited from a new representative, and that representative is Christ, the second Adam. If sin is offensive to God, it must be punished, and Christ has taken that punishment on himself.

The doctrine of sin is bad news. But every Christian doctrine of grace is only good news because of how bad the news of sin is. The depth of the disease tells you the depth of the cure. If sin were only a failure of effort, Christ's death on the cross would be absurd overkill. But if sin is what Scripture says it is, then Christ's death is precisely what we need.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 3 and Romans 5 together tell us not just what sin is, but how it works.

In Genesis 3, sin begins with doubting God's word. The serpent's first question is "Did God actually say?" Before Eve had eaten anything, the soil of her heart was being prepared for rebellion by being asked to question what God had spoken. This is still how sin operates today. Long before a Christian falls into open disobedience, the foundation has usually been laid by questioning whether God really said what he said, really means what he means, really cares what he cares about. Watch the pattern. Sin always starts with the word.

Then sin moves to distrust of God's character. The serpent does not just question the content of God's word; he attacks God's motives. "God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God." Translated: God is holding out on you. He is not generous; he is stingy. He is not a good Father; he is a withholding tyrant. This lie is in every temptation you face. If you could see that God is good and that his command is for your flourishing, sin would lose almost all of its power. But the serpent works to make God look smaller, meaner, and less trustworthy than he is.

Finally, sin culminates in self-deification, the desire to be the one who decides what is good and what is evil. This is the heart of sin. Not just disobedience to a command, but the assertion of moral autonomy: I will define right and wrong for myself. Every sin is, in some

sense, a small repetition of this. Whenever you choose to override what God has said because you have decided your way is wiser, kinder, more loving, or more reasonable, you are echoing Eden.

Romans 5 then takes this story and tells you why it matters for you. Paul's argument is breathtaking in its scope. The world we live in, full of death, decay, injustice, futility, is the world that Adam's sin has brought about. Not because each of us has personally sinned the way Adam did (though we have), but because we are all in Adam. The technical term is "federal headship." Adam represented humanity. His fall was our fall. His exile was our exile. His death is our death.

But that is not the end of Paul's argument. He sets up the contrast precisely so he can flip it. If one man's disobedience could plunge all of humanity into sin and death, then one man's obedience can lift all who are in him out of sin and death. That second man is Christ. Just as we were in Adam by birth, we are in Christ by faith. Just as Adam's failure was counted as ours, Christ's success is counted as ours. Just as we inherited death from Adam, we inherit life from Christ. The whole gospel hinges on this parallel.

So the doctrine of sin is not Christianity's primary message. It is the dark background against which the bright news of Christ stands out. You cannot understand the gospel without it. You cannot rejoice in the cross until you have grieved over Eden. But once you have done both, you will see the wonder of what Christ has done with a clarity that no shallower doctrine could ever produce.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 and 2 showed us what we were meant to be, image-bearers in covenant with God, called to rule the world he made. Genesis 3 showed us what we became, exiles, hiding, ashamed, dying. The doctrine of sin is the bridge that explains every other tension in Scripture. It is why the law has to be given. It is why blood has to be shed. It is why prophets weep and kings fail. It is why God's people need a Savior, not just a teacher or a king. And it is why, when Christ enters the world in the New Testament, he comes not as a moral example to imitate but as a substitute to die. As you continue reading, you will see this doctrine confirmed at every turn, and you will see, with growing clarity, why the gospel of Christ is the only answer to the catastrophe of Genesis 3.

STEP 6

Application

Take sin seriously. This is hard in a culture that wants to soften every category and rename every failure. But you will not grow as a Christian if you minimize what is actually wrong with you. The depth of grace can only be felt by those who have honestly faced the depth of sin.

Practically, three habits help. First, regular self-examination, not in a morbid way, but honestly asking God to show you where you have sinned in the past day, week, month. The psalmist's prayer is a good one: "Search me, O God, and know my heart" (Psalm 139:23). Second, confession, both in personal prayer and, when appropriate, with trusted believers. Sin loses much of its power when it is brought into the light. Third, repentance, not just feeling bad about sin, but turning from it toward Christ, again and again.

But also, take grace seriously. The doctrine of sin is not meant to keep you in despair. It is meant to drive you to Christ. If you are in him, the verdict over you is no longer "in Adam, condemned" but "in Christ, justified." The sin still in you does not define you; Christ does. The doctrine of sin should produce humility, not self-loathing. It should produce vigilance, not paranoia. It should produce gratitude, because you know what you have been rescued from.

If you have never trusted in Christ as the Savior who bore your sin and gave you his righteousness, today is a good day to do so. The serpent's lie was that God is not good. Christ's death is the answer: God is so good that he sent his own Son to bear what we deserved.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly what you see when you look at your own heart, and ask for his mercy.
- Thank Jesus for doing what Adam failed to do.
- Ask him to keep you close to the cross, taking sin seriously and grace more seriously still.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

“In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.”

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 7 · WEEK 1

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This is your weekly Sabbath, a day to rest from the work of new content and to let what you have read this week settle into your heart. If you can, set aside your normal time for this rest day just as you would for any reading day. The discipline of stopping is its own form of worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

REST

Meditation

Spend a few minutes saying this verse aloud. Say it slowly. Say it again. The goal of weekly memory work is not perfection but possession, by the end of this week, you should be able to recall this verse from memory without effort.

Sit with the verse phrase by phrase. "In the beginning", there was a beginning, and God was already there. "God created", not chaos, not gods, not accidents. "The heavens and the earth", everything that is, in every realm. Seven English words that refute atheism, polytheism, pantheism, dualism, and naturalism all at once.

Carry this verse with you through the day. When you see something beautiful in creation, say it. When something feels chaotic in your life, say it. When you wake tomorrow, say it again. By next week, it will be yours.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This was the first week of the plan. You began with creation itself, Genesis 1, the ordered making of all things by the speech of God. You paused on the doctrine of Scripture and learned why this book carries the very breath of God. You read Genesis 2 and saw humanity as image-bearers in covenant with their Maker. You paused again on the image of God, what it means to be human, and why every person you meet bears irreducible dignity. You read Genesis 3 and watched the fall, the first sin, the first promise of a Redeemer. And you paused a third time on the doctrine of sin, universal, deep, inherited, offensive to God, and the very thing Christ came to bear.

Six days. Three readings. Three doctrinal anchors. This is the foundation under everything else you will read in the next two years. The God who created. The image he made. The Scripture he gave. The sin we committed. The Redeemer he promised. Every page that follows builds on what you read this week.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What is one thing about God's character this week that struck you in a new way? The first chapters of Genesis introduce God as Creator, as the one who speaks, as the one who walks with his people, as the one who calls humans into covenant, as the one who pursues them even after they have fallen. Where did your sense of who God is deepen this week?

How does this week's reading point you to Christ? The doctrine of Scripture you read on Day 2 reaches its climax in the Word made flesh. The image of God you read about on Day 4 is fully and perfectly seen in Jesus, the true image of the invisible God. The doctrine of sin you read on Day 6 is the very catastrophe Christ came to undo. Where have you seen Christ in the foundations this week, and where do you most need to bring your sin and rest in his finished work?

What does it mean for you, today, that every person you encounter bears the image of God? Whose face will you see this week that you have not been treating as an image-bearer?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the week behind you, and for one thing he has shown you about himself.

Rest in what he has done instead of what you must still understand, and say so to him.

Ask him to settle the memory verse in your heart.

DAY 8 · WEEK 2

Psalm 8

The glory of God in creation and the dignity of man

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 8 slowly, twice, and aloud if you can. It is short, only nine verses. Notice that it begins and ends with the same line, and notice the question in the middle: “What is man that you are mindful of him?” Let the psalm lead you to look at the night sky as the psalmist did.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Psalms are the prayer book of the Bible, the songs, laments, and praises that the people of God have prayed for three thousand years. They were sung in the Temple, prayed by Jesus on the cross, and read in the church from the beginning. This plan weaves them in alongside the historical books because the Psalms teach us not just what God has done, but how to respond to him. Psalm 8 is the first Psalm we will read together, and it is fitting: it picks up exactly where the last three days have left us, meditating on the same creation and the same dignity of humanity that Genesis 1-2 described.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens and closes with the same line: “O LORD, our Lord, how majestic is your name in all the earth.” This is called an inclusio, it frames the whole psalm in worship.
2. Babies and infants are mentioned in verse 2 as the means by which God establishes strength against his enemies. Strength comes from unexpected places in God’s economy.
3. The psalm moves from the cosmic (the heavens, the moon, the stars) to the personal (what is man that you are mindful of him?) and back to the cosmic.

4. The question “what is man?” is asked in the middle of looking at the night sky. Smallness is felt; the answer comes anyway: humanity has been crowned with glory and honor.

5. Verses 6-8 echo Genesis 1:26-28, dominion over the works of God’s hands, all things under his feet.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 8 is David’s response to the same wonder that Genesis 1 and 2 set up. Looking at the night sky, David asks the question every honest person eventually asks: in this enormous universe, why does humanity matter? The stars are vast. The moon hangs distant and unchanging. Compared to the cosmos, a human being is small, fragile, and temporary. So why does God care?

David’s answer is not that humanity is, in fact, more impressive than it seems. It is that God has chosen to crown humanity with glory and honor. The dignity of humans is not earned, it is given. We have value because God has assigned us value, made us in his image, and given us responsibility over what he has made. Verse 6 directly echoes Genesis 1:28: “You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet.”

But the psalm has a depth that the New Testament will later uncover. When the writer of Hebrews quotes Psalm 8 in Hebrews 2, he applies it to Jesus. “You have crowned him with glory and honor”, yes, that is true of humanity in general, but it is most truly fulfilled in the one true human, the second Adam, who succeeded where the first Adam failed. Jesus is the man who actually fulfills the role Psalm 8 describes, the human under whose feet all things will finally be subjected. Already, Hebrews says, we see him “crowned with glory and honor because of the suffering of death.” The dignity of humanity, lost in Genesis 3, is recovered in Christ.

So Psalm 8 is both a celebration of the dignity God has given us and a confession of the wonder that God should bother with us at all. It is honest about smallness. The night sky humbles. But the smallness only makes the love of God more astonishing. He sees you. He knows your name. He has crowned you with glory and honor. This is the truth that Christianity proclaims against every philosophy that says humans are accidents and against every culture that reduces humans to their usefulness.

STEP 5

Connection

For three days we have been reading Genesis, the creation, the garden, the fall. Psalm 8 is the appropriate response. It looks at what God has made and worships. It looks at what God has done for humanity and marvels. And it does so without yet knowing what we know, that the one truly crowned with glory and honor will be Jesus, the Son of David, in whom the dignity of humanity is finally restored. Pray this Psalm today as someone who knows the rest of the story.

STEP 6

Application

Read this Psalm again, slowly, as a prayer. When you reach the question "what is man that you are mindful of him?", let yourself sit with both the smallness and the dignity. You are smaller than you think and more loved than you can imagine.

This week, look at the sky at night, if you can. Let it remind you of how vast God's creation is, and let that vastness lead you to worship rather than despair. Then look at the people around you, your spouse, your children, the cashier at the store, the stranger in traffic, and remember that each of them has been crowned with glory and honor by God. The doctrine of human dignity is not a slogan; it is a practice. It changes how you treat the people God has made.

And finally, look at yourself. If you have ever wondered whether you matter, Psalm 8 answers you. The God who counts and names every star is mindful of you. The maker of galaxies cares about your life. You are not an accident, and you are not insignificant. You are an image-bearer crowned with glory by the Creator of all things, and in Christ that glory is being restored.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Stand in wonder before God's majesty, and tell him what stirs in you when you think of how small you are and how much he has given you.

Thank him that Christ restores the dignity Adam lost.

Ask him to help you see each person you meet today as crowned with honor.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

“The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.”

PSALM 19:1

DAY 9 · WEEK 2

Psalm 104:1-23

God as creator, O LORD, how manifold are your works

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 104:1-23 slowly, twice. This psalm retells the creation story as praise. As you read, see if you can match its verses to the days of Genesis 1, and notice how God is pictured as providing for every creature, from the wild goats to the lions to the people who work the land.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 104 is one of the longest creation poems in the Bible, and it follows the same order as Genesis 1: light, heavens, waters, earth, vegetation, sun and moon, creatures, humanity. The psalmist appears to be deliberately taking us back through Genesis 1, but as praise rather than narrative. If Genesis 1 is the architect's blueprint, Psalm 104 is the hymn sung when you walk through the finished house and marvel at the craftsman. Today's reading covers the first two-thirds, through the work of the day. We will save verses 24-35 for another day in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with the same call as Psalm 103: "Bless the LORD, O my soul." This is self-talk, the psalmist commanding his own heart to worship.
2. God is described as clothed in splendor and majesty, wrapped in light, riding on the clouds. The imagery is regal and cosmic.
3. The order of creation in this psalm mirrors Genesis 1: light, the firmament, the waters, dry land, vegetation, the heavenly bodies, the creatures.
4. Notice how much attention is given to water, springs gushing, rivers running, animals drinking. Water is life in the ancient Near East, and the psalmist sees it everywhere as

evidence of God's provision.

5. Verses 19-23 take the same heavenly bodies that Genesis 1 calls "lights" and shows them at work: the moon marks seasons, the sun governs the rhythm of work and rest for both humans and animals.

6. Even the lions are seen as "seeking their food from God", predators included in the picture of God's provision.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 104 is what creation theology looks like when it is set on fire. The same God who, in Genesis 1, simply spoke and reality obeyed, is here described in vivid, sensory language. He wraps himself in light as a garment. He stretches out the heavens like a tent. He makes the clouds his chariot and walks on the wings of the wind. The psalm is not just telling us that God made creation; it is showing us that God is intimately involved with every part of it.

This is a crucial corrective to a common misunderstanding. Many people, even Christians, drift toward a kind of deism, the idea that God created the world like a watchmaker, wound it up, and now stands back to watch it run. Psalm 104 refuses that picture. God is not absent from his creation. He is sustaining it moment by moment. The springs in the valleys are flowing right now because God makes them flow. The grass grows for the cattle because God makes it grow. The young lions roar because God provides their food. Every animal you have ever seen drink from a stream is participating in the providence of God.

The structure of the psalm mirrors Genesis 1 deliberately. The same order, light first, then heavens, then waters, then dry land, then vegetation, then heavenly bodies, then animal life, but where Genesis tells you what God did, Psalm 104 tells you that God is still doing it. The verbs are present tense. He is making the wind his messenger right now. He is covering the earth with the deep right now. He is making springs to gush forth right now. This is the doctrine of providence, that God's care of his creation did not stop at the end of the sixth day. It continues, every second, in every corner of what he has made.

Verse 23 is especially worth lingering on. After describing the night when the lions hunt, the psalm says: "Man goes out to his work and to his labor until the evening." Human work is part of the rhythm of creation. The sun rises, animals retreat, humans go out to labor, all of it under God's ordering. The work you will do today, however mundane, however tiring, is part of the symphony of creation that Psalm 104 is celebrating. You are not interrupting God's work by going to your job. You are participating in it.

This is the kind of meditation Psalm 104 teaches us. To see creation rightly is to see the Creator behind every part of it. To look at a tree is to see God's craftsmanship. To feel rain on your face is to feel God's provision. To hear birds in the morning is to hear what God is feeding right now. The whole world becomes a sanctuary when you read it through this psalm.

STEP 5

Connection

The first three days of this plan walked through Genesis 1 to 3. Yesterday we let David teach us how to respond to the creation account with Psalm 8, the dignity of humanity. Today the psalmist takes us deeper into the wonder of creation itself. Tomorrow we will return to narrative as Genesis continues. The Psalms are not interruptions to the story; they are the heart's response to the story. As the plan unfolds, watch how the Psalms keep reframing what we have just read in the language of prayer, lament, and praise. The Bible is not just telling you about God; it is teaching you how to talk back to him.

STEP 6

Application

Today, take Psalm 104 with you. As you go through your day, practice what the psalmist practices: noticing God's hand in what would normally be background. The water from your tap. The food on your plate. The light in the sky. The wind in the trees. The birds you hear. None of these are accidents. All of them are God's ongoing creative care, sustained moment by moment by his word.

If you have time, take a short walk outside today and let Psalm 104 shape your eyes. Notice five things you might normally walk past, and silently thank God for each. The point is not to feel mystical, the point is to recover sight. We live in a world that has trained us to see creation as raw material, as background, as something we use. Psalm 104 trains us to see it as a hymn we are walking through. Recovering this vision changes how you treat your food, your body, your environment, and your neighbor. Worship begins with seeing.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD for something you can see or touch right now that he is sustaining.

Ask him to help you receive today's work and meals as gifts and not as entitlements.

Tell him what it would mean to walk through this day as through a temple.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

“The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.”

PSALM 19:1

DAY 10 · WEEK 2

Psalm 104:24-35

Creation praises its maker; the Spirit renews the face of the ground

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 104:24-35 slowly, twice. Yesterday you read the first half of this psalm. Today you read the conclusion. As you read, notice how the psalm shifts from describing creation to praising the Creator, and how it ends with a startling line about the wicked, before closing in worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second half of Psalm 104, the great creation hymn we began yesterday. The first half walked us through the order of creation in the same sequence as Genesis 1. Now the psalmist steps back to take in the whole picture, the manifold works of God, the dependence of every creature on his hand, the sea and its creatures, the cycle of breath and death, and finally the worship that all this should produce. The psalm ends as it began: "Bless the LORD, O my soul."

For new believers, this Psalm is a school of seeing. It teaches us to look at creation not as a backdrop or a resource but as a hymn of God's craftsmanship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 24 is the great summary: "O LORD, how manifold are your works! In wisdom have you made them all." The whole psalm is gathered into one cry of wonder.
2. The sea, often a symbol of chaos in the Bible, is here just another part of God's well-ordered domain. Even Leviathan, the great mythic sea monster, is reduced to a creature who "plays" in the water.
3. Every living thing is described as dependent on God for food, breath, and life itself. When he opens his hand, they are filled; when he hides his face, they are dismayed.

4. Verses 29-30 form a remarkable picture: God "takes away their breath" and they die, then "sends forth your Spirit, they are created", the language of ongoing creation through the Spirit.

5. The psalmist's response is to commit himself to lifelong praise: "I will sing to the LORD as long as I live."

6. Verse 35 is jarring: "Let sinners be consumed from the earth, and let the wicked be no more." Even a creation psalm acknowledges that something is wrong with the world.

7. The psalm closes with "Praise the LORD", the first appearance of the word "Hallelujah" in the Psalter.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of Psalm 104 takes everything described in the first half and gathers it into one great act of worship. Verse 24 is the hinge: "O LORD, how manifold are your works! In wisdom have you made them all; the earth is full of your possessions." Every creature, every detail, every system in the natural world is the work of God's wisdom. The psalmist is not just looking at the world; he is reading it as a manuscript of divine craftsmanship.

The sea passage is especially worth pausing over. In the ancient Near East, the sea symbolized chaos, danger, and the realm where gods battled monsters. But Psalm 104 reframes it completely. The sea is just another part of God's good order. Ships pass through it. Creatures live in it. And Leviathan, the dreaded sea-monster of pagan mythology, is reduced to a creature that "plays" in God's waters like a dolphin in a tide pool. The God of Psalm 104 has no rivals. What other religions feared, he created and tamed.

Then comes the most theologically rich section: verses 27-30. Every creature looks to God for food. When he gives, they are filled. When he hides his face, they are dismayed. When he takes away their breath, they die. When he sends his Spirit, they are created and the face of the ground is renewed. Christian readers have always noticed the trinitarian echoes here, Father, Spirit, and the implicit Word, at work in ongoing creation. The Spirit who hovered over the waters in Genesis 1:2 is still active in sustaining and renewing what God has made. Creation is not a one-time event in the distant past. It is a present, continuous act of God.

The psalm reaches its climactic resolve in verses 33-34: "I will sing to the LORD as long as I live; I will sing praise to my God while I have being. May my meditation be pleasing to him, for I rejoice in the LORD." The right response to creation is not awe alone, or even gratitude alone, but worship, the deliberate, sustained, lifelong singing of praise to the Creator. This is what creation is for. It is not just a stage on which human dramas unfold. It is a sanctuary in which the Creator is to be worshiped.

And then, just when you expect a peaceful close, comes verse 35. “Let sinners be consumed from the earth, and let the wicked be no more.” It is a jarring line in such a serene psalm. Why is it here? Because the psalmist cannot praise creation without acknowledging that something is wrong with creation. The world that God called “very good” is now full of sinners and wickedness. Genesis 3 has happened. The psalm refuses to be naive about this. Praise of the Creator and longing for the renewal of creation are not in tension, they belong together. The same God who made all things will one day cleanse all things. And until then, the believer praises him both for what he has made and for what he will yet do.

The psalm closes with “Bless the LORD, O my soul. Praise the LORD.” The first “Hallelujah” in the Psalter. Worship is the final note.

STEP 5

Connection

For two days you have been meditating on Psalm 104, God’s creation as ongoing wonder. But notice how the psalm refuses to stop at creation. It ends with a longing for the wicked to be no more, and with an unrestrained burst of praise. This is the same arc you will see throughout this plan: the Bible never stays at creation alone, because creation is broken. The story moves through Fall, redemption, and toward new creation. Psalm 104 already feels the tension and looks forward to the resolution. When you reach Revelation at the end of this plan, the new creation will be the answer to Psalm 104:35, wickedness will be no more, and creation will sing the praise of God forever.

STEP 6

Application

Spend some time today simply praising God for creation. Not as a meditation technique or a stress-relief practice, but as the response that creation itself demands. The psalmist resolved: “I will sing to the LORD as long as I live.” Can you say the same? If not yet, can today be a day to begin?

Practically: walk outside if possible, even briefly, and let yourself see. Notice three things, a tree, the wind, a bird, the warmth of the sun, anything. Name them silently as gifts. Then say, in your own words or in the psalmist’s: “How manifold are your works, O LORD! In wisdom you have made them all.” Worship begins with seeing, and seeing must become saying.

But also, do not flinch from verse 35. The world is broken. There is wickedness in it, in others and in your own heart. Praise of creation that ignores this is dishonest. The Christian’s praise of the Creator always includes a longing for the Creator to come and make all things new. Pray today not just “thank you” but also “come, Lord Jesus.” Both prayers belong in the mouth of every believer who reads Psalm 104.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for the wisdom in what he has made, in your own words.

Thank him for the Spirit who renews, and ask him to renew something in you that feels worn out.

Pray “Come, Lord,” longing for the day when all things are made new.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

“The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.”

PSALM 19:1

DAY 11 · WEEK 2

Psalm 19:1-6

The heavens declare the glory of God

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19:1-6 slowly, twice. This is the opening section of one of the most famous psalms in Scripture. C.S. Lewis called it "the greatest poem in the Psalter and one of the greatest lyrics in the world." Notice the wordless preaching it describes, and how creation itself becomes a sermon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is famously structured in three movements: the first six verses praise God for his revelation in creation, the next five praise him for his revelation in the law, and the closing verses turn to personal prayer. Today's reading covers the first movement only, the wordless witness of the heavens. The plan will return to verses 7-14 on another day, when the law has become more central to our reading.

This first section is a meditation on what theologians call general revelation, the knowledge of God that is available to all people, everywhere, through what he has made. Long before any Bible reaches a human soul, the heavens are already preaching.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first verse is one of the most quoted in Scripture: "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."
2. The preaching of creation happens "day to day" and "night to night", it never stops.
3. Verse 3 contains a striking paradox: "There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard." Creation's witness is wordless but universally audible.
4. The "voice" of creation has gone out "through all the earth", Paul will quote this verse in Romans 10:18 to describe the spread of the gospel.

5. The sun is described in vivid poetic imagery, a bridegroom emerging from his chamber, a strong man running his course with joy.

6. Nothing in creation is hidden from the sun's heat, a poetic image of how thoroughly God's witness penetrates the world.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 19:1-6 makes a quiet but enormous claim: God has not left himself without a witness. Every star, every dawn, every sunset, every breath of wind has been speaking about him since the beginning. The witness is constant ("day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge"), universal ("their voice goes out through all the earth"), and silent. This is what is meant by general revelation.

The wordlessness matters. Creation is not preaching with sermons or sentences. It is preaching with its very existence. The fact that there is something rather than nothing, that the something is ordered rather than chaotic, that the something is breathtakingly beautiful rather than merely functional, these things are themselves a testimony. As Paul will say in Romans 1, since the creation of the world, God's "invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse." Every human being who has ever lived has been preached to by the heavens.

This means something important about evangelism and missions. When the gospel arrives in a new place, it is never the first word about God that has reached that place. The heavens have already been speaking for thousands of years. The gospel is not introducing God to people who have heard nothing. It is naming and identifying the God whom every human has already been hearing about, wordlessly, since the day they were born. This is why Paul could preach in Athens by quoting their own poets, and why missionaries often find their message resonating in cultures that, on the surface, seem to have no connection to Christianity.

But general revelation has limits. The heavens declare that God exists, that he is powerful, that he is good. They do not declare that humanity is fallen, that Christ has come, or how to be saved. For that, you need special revelation, the words of Scripture, the gospel of Christ. General revelation is sufficient to leave humanity without excuse. It is not sufficient to save. That is why the psalm itself does not stop at verse 6. The next section turns to the law, the special revelation of God in his Word. Both are necessary. Both are gifts.

The image of the sun is particularly worth meditating on. The psalmist personifies the sun as a bridegroom emerging from his marriage chamber, full of joy and strength, running his course across the sky, leaving nothing hidden from his heat. This is not the sun-worship of pagans. It is the use of a vivid image to communicate something about God himself. God's revelation, like the sun, reaches everywhere. Nothing is hidden from it. The light of God's glory is the universal background of human existence, even when we close our eyes to it.

The deeper Christian reading of this image is that Jesus Christ is the true Sun of righteousness (Malachi 4:2), the one through whom God's full glory enters the world. The wordless preaching of the heavens has now been joined by the audible preaching of the Word made flesh. The same God who has been signaling himself through every sunrise has now spoken plainly through his Son.

STEP 5

Connection

For ten days now, this plan has been meditating on creation. Genesis 1 and 2 told us how it was made. Genesis 3 told us how it fell. Psalm 8, Psalm 104, and now Psalm 19 teach us how to respond to it. The pattern is becoming clear: creation is meant to lead us to the Creator, and the Creator has chosen to be revealed not only in the wordless preaching of the heavens but also, ultimately, in the spoken word of Scripture and the incarnate Word who is Christ. As you finish this first week of reading, you have begun to inhabit the basic biblical instinct: see the world, see the Maker; see the Maker, fall on your knees and worship.

STEP 6

Application

Today, let creation preach to you. The next time you step outside, the next time you see the sun rise or set, the next time you look up at the night sky, listen. The heavens are still declaring the glory of God. The question is not whether they are speaking; the question is whether you are paying attention.

A practical exercise: take a few minutes today to look at the sky. It does not need to be at a famous landmark or in beautiful weather. The sky above your driveway, your apartment building, your office, will do. Stand there for two or three minutes and let yourself hear what it is saying. Then say aloud (or silently, if that's better): "The heavens declare the glory of God." That is not a feeling; it is a fact. The sky is preaching. Your job is to receive the sermon.

But also: do not be content with general revelation. Psalm 19 itself does not stop at verse 6, and neither should you. The heavens point you to God; the Bible names him as your Father in Christ. Both belong together in the Christian life. The believer who learns to see the

wordless witness of creation and the spoken witness of Scripture is the believer whose worship is full.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that creation keeps speaking of him, and ask him to give you ears to hear it.
- Confess any days you have walked under his sky without noticing him.
- Thank him that he has spoken more clearly still in his Son.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 12 · WEEK 2

Psalm 33:1-9

By the word of the LORD the heavens were made

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 33:1-9 slowly, twice. This psalm begins with a call to worship and quickly turns to the same theme our recent readings have explored, the word of the LORD as the agent of creation. Read it aloud if you can. The psalm was originally meant to be sung.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 33 is one of the great praise psalms of the Psalter. It opens with a vigorous call to worship, shouts, songs, harps, lyres, new songs sung well. Then in verses 6-9 it grounds that worship in a specific theological claim: by the word of the LORD the heavens were made. This little psalm captures, in a few lines, what Genesis 1 narrated and Psalms 8, 19, and 104 celebrated.

The whole opening third of this plan is meditating on God as Creator. Today's psalm crystallizes one specific aspect of that doctrine: God created by speaking, and his word still carries the same power today.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with five different verbs of praise: shout, give thanks, sing, play skillfully, sing aloud. Worship is not lazy; it is energetic.
2. Praise is described as "fitting for the upright", worship is the natural and right response of the righteous.
3. Verses 4-5 ground praise in God's character: his word is upright, his work faithful, he loves righteousness and justice, the earth is full of his steadfast love.
4. Verse 6 is the theological climax: "By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host." This directly echoes Genesis 1.

5. The Hebrew for “breath” (ruach) is the same word used for “Spirit”, the trinitarian echoes are subtle but real.
6. God “gathers the waters of the sea as a heap”, taming the chaotic waters with the ease of stacking blocks.
7. Verse 9 sums up the doctrine of creation by word: “For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 33:1-9 is a compact meditation on what theologians call creation by divine fiat, the doctrine that God created by speaking, and that his speech carries the power to bring reality into being. It is the doctrine of Genesis 1 set to music.

The psalm begins with the call to worship. Notice the verbs: shout, give thanks, sing, play, sing aloud. Worship in the Psalter is not a quiet, internal feeling. It is a public, embodied, often loud act. The instruments are named, harp, ten-stringed lyre. The skill is required, “play skillfully.” A “new song” is called for, not just rote repetition. Christian worship has always taken this seriously. Why? Because the God we worship is worthy of more than half-hearted attention.

Then comes the foundation. Why is God worthy of this energy of praise? Verses 4-5: because his word is upright, his work is faithful, he loves righteousness and justice, and the earth is full of his steadfast love. This is the theological ground beneath worship. We do not praise God because we feel like it, or because of what we hope to get, or because praise is good for us (though it is). We praise God because of who he is and what he has done. The verbs of praise in verses 1-3 are anchored in the truths about God in verses 4-5.

Then verse 6 arrives, and it is one of the most concentrated creation statements in the Old Testament: “By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host.” The structure is parallel: word and breath, made and all their host. The word of the LORD is not just a sound; it is the agent of creation. The breath of his mouth is not just air; it is the Spirit at work. This is why John could later begin his Gospel with “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.” John was not introducing a new idea; he was identifying the eternal Word through whom Psalm 33:6 says the heavens were made, and revealing that Word as the Son of God.

This is the doctrine that Christians call divine speech-act. God’s words do things. When God says “let there be light,” there is light. When God says “be still” to a storm, the storm becomes calm. When God says “your sins are forgiven,” sins are forgiven. The same power that made

the universe is at work whenever God speaks. This is why the Bible matters. This is why preaching matters. This is why prayer matters. We are dealing with a God whose word is creative.

Verse 7 describes the taming of the waters, God gathers the seas as a heap. In Genesis 1, the waters of chaos were separated and ordered. In Exodus 14, the Red Sea was parted as a heap. In the Gospels, Christ walks on the water and calms the storm with a word. The God of Psalm 33 has been doing this his whole story: speaking, and chaos becoming order.

The psalm concludes the section with verse 9, which is almost a confessional summary of the doctrine: "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm." This is who God is. And this is the God we worship.

STEP 5

Connection

For more than a week now, this plan has been circling around creation, Genesis 1 and 2, Psalm 8, Psalm 104, Psalm 19, and now Psalm 33. Each angle has shown something slightly different: creation's order, humanity's dignity, the wordless preaching of the heavens, the still-flowing providence of God. Psalm 33 zooms in on the mechanism: God spoke. This will become crucial as the plan continues. The God who speaks the universe into being is the God who will later speak through his prophets, then through his Son, then through the apostles. The whole Bible is the speech of the God of Psalm 33:9. When we read it, we are not consulting religious literature, we are listening to the voice that made the stars.

STEP 6

Application

Take the power of God's word seriously today. Twice over.

First, when you open Scripture, remember that the same word that made the heavens is what you are reading. That is why Scripture reading is not just information-gathering. It is communion with the living God. When you open your Bible, you are sitting under the voice that called galaxies into being. Ask yourself how you usually approach it, and what would change if you came expecting to be addressed.

Second, take the energy of worship seriously. The psalm calls for shouts, songs, instruments, skill, new songs. If your worship has gone flat, if it has become a routine, a habit, a duty, Psalm 33 is a prophetic reminder that God deserves more. This is not about being emotional for its own sake. It is about giving the God who spoke the universe into being the response he is owed. Sing on your way to work. Listen to a worship song between meetings. Read a hymn before bed. Let the energy of praise come back into the corners of your week where it has slipped away.

And when you face circumstances today that feel chaotic, uncertain plans, difficult relationships, struggles in your own heart, remember verse 9. He speaks, and it comes to be. The God who tamed the waters is the same God who can speak peace into your storms.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Marvel that the God who spoke the universe into being speaks to you, and tell him what that does to the way you open his Word.

Bring him one chaotic area of your life and ask him to speak peace into it.

Ask him to revive your worship where it has gone flat.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 13 · WEEK 2

Psalm 29

The voice of the LORD over the waters

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 29 slowly, twice. This is one of the shortest and most thunderous psalms in the Psalter. Read it aloud if you can. As you read, pay attention to the repeated phrase "the voice of the LORD", it appears seven times, and it is the spine of the whole poem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 29 is widely considered one of the oldest psalms in the Hebrew Bible. Its imagery, the LORD enthroned over the flood, the voice that shatters cedars and shakes the wilderness, uses storm-language that the surrounding pagan cultures used for their storm-gods. But the psalm radically reframes the imagery. Whatever the Canaanites attributed to Baal, the Psalter attributes to the one true God. The storm belongs to him alone.

This psalm closes our string of creation meditations in a thunderous way. Where Psalm 19 heard creation's quiet, wordless witness, Psalm 29 hears its booming, shaking, magnificent voice. Both are true, and both belong to the same God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a call to the "heavenly beings" (literally "sons of God") to ascribe glory to the LORD. Even the angels are summoned to worship.
2. The phrase "the voice of the LORD" appears seven times in seven verses. Seven is the number of completeness in Hebrew thought.
3. Each occurrence of "the voice of the LORD" shows that voice doing something powerful in nature: thundering over waters, breaking cedars, flashing flames of fire, shaking the wilderness, twisting oaks.

4. Verse 9 ends with the surprising note: in his temple, "all cry, Glory!" Even creation's chaos becomes a sanctuary of praise.
5. Verse 10 says "The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever." He is not threatened by chaos; he reigns over it.
6. The psalm ends with a benediction: "May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!" Power leads to peace.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 29 is one of the most theologically rich short psalms in the Bible. In just eleven verses, it gathers up the doctrine of God's sovereignty, the worship of the heavenly host, the power of God's voice over chaos, and the blessing of peace upon his people. The whole psalm is built around the sevenfold repetition of one phrase: "the voice of the LORD."

The psalm begins by addressing the "heavenly beings", angels, the divine council, the celestial court. The call is for them to ascribe to the LORD glory and strength. This is significant. Worship is not just a human activity. The angels worship. The heavens worship. The whole created universe is summoned to give glory to the God who made it. When you worship as a Christian, you are not initiating a private religious moment, you are joining an unbroken cosmic chorus that has been praising God since before you were born.

Then the storm rolls in. Beginning in verse 3, the psalm describes the voice of the LORD with vivid, almost violent imagery. It thunders over the waters. It is powerful and full of majesty. It breaks the cedars of Lebanon, and the cedars of Lebanon were the strongest, tallest trees in the ancient Near East. It makes Lebanon skip like a calf. It flashes forth flames of fire. It shakes the wilderness. It strips the forests bare. The same voice that whispered in Genesis 1 also thunders. The same voice that gently spoke creation into being can shake the foundations of the world.

This is important pastoral theology. Many people, when they think of God, imagine either a gentle grandfather figure or a distant cosmic principle. Psalm 29 shatters both pictures. The God of the Bible is glorious in a way that should make the cedars tremble. He is no tame deity. He is the maker and sustainer of all things, and his voice can rip the earth open.

And yet, and this is the breathtaking turn, verse 9 ends with this surprising line: "in his temple all cry, Glory!" In the middle of all this thunder, in the holy sanctuary of God's presence, there is one response: worship. The shaking forests, the trembling wilderness, the broken cedars, they are all part of one great hymn. Even chaos cannot help but praise the Creator.

Then verse 10 brings the great theological summary: “The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever.” The flood here likely echoes both the Genesis flood and the chaotic waters of creation. The point is the same in both cases: God is not threatened by the chaos. He reigns over it. Whatever is shaking your life today, political turmoil, personal crisis, fear of the future, God sits enthroned over it. He is king forever.

The psalm ends, then, with a quiet benediction: “May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!” The God whose voice shakes the world gives strength and peace to his people. The same power that shatters the cedars protects and blesses his children. Power in the service of love is the heart of the Christian God.

STEP 5

Connection

A week ago we read in Genesis 1 that God spoke creation into being. In the days since, the Psalms have echoed that creation theme in many ways, the dignity of humanity, the manifold works of the Maker, the wordless witness of the heavens, the breath of his mouth as agent of creation. Today’s psalm completes the picture by showing us what that voice sounds like in its full power, and that it always ends in blessing for God’s people. The God who made the universe by speaking is the same God who will one day still every storm with a word, and whose voice will say to his redeemed: “Behold, I am making all things new.” The voice of the LORD has been the spine of every reading we have done. It will be the spine of everything yet to come.

STEP 6

Application

Worship God for his greatness today. Not just for his goodness, that you are familiar with, but for his greatness. The God of Psalm 29 is not a comfortable deity to manage. He is a thundering Lord whose voice shakes the wilderness. If your sense of God has shrunk to the size of your prayer requests, this psalm is a prophetic correction.

Today, find one place where you can experience something of the power of creation. The wind in trees. A thunderstorm if there is one. A vast view. The sound of a river. And let it remind you that the God you worship is the God whose voice still shakes the cedars. Then worship him for that. Not just thank him; ascribe to him glory and strength. The fact that he is so much greater than you is not bad news, it is the reason you can trust him with everything.

But also receive verse 11 today: “May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!” The same God whose voice splits the wilderness gives you strength and peace as his child. If you feel weak, ask for his strength. If you are anxious, ask

for his peace. The power that shook Lebanon is at your service through Christ, who has reconciled you to the King who sits enthroned forever.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ascribe glory and strength to the LORD in your own words.

Name a storm you are facing and remind yourself that he sits enthroned over every flood.

Ask him for the peace he promises to his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 14 · WEEK 2

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. After a week of creation Psalms, this is the right day to step outside if you can, look up, and simply receive what creation has been preaching. The Sabbath is not just rest from work, it is rest into worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

REST

Meditation

Read this verse aloud several times. Then sit with the two halves. "The heavens declare", they are constantly speaking, day and night, in every place. "The glory of God", not their own beauty, not random wonder, but the glory of a Person. The sky preaches. The question is whether we are listening.

The Hebrew word for "declare" is intense, it is the language of proclamation, of a herald announcing news. The heavens are not whispering. They are heralding. Every sunrise is a sermon. Every star is a syllable in a sentence about God's glory.

Carry this verse with you outdoors today, even briefly. Look up. Hear what is being said. By the end of this week, the verse should rise to your mind every time you see the sky.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This was a week entirely of creation Psalms. You read Psalm 8, where David marveled that the God of the stars cares for humanity. You read both halves of Psalm 104, walking through creation as ongoing providence. You read Psalm 19:1-6, where the heavens preach without words. You read Psalm 33:1-9, where creation is grounded in the power of God's spoken word. And you read Psalm 29, where the voice of the LORD thundered seven times across the wilderness.

Six Psalms. One theme. Six different angles on the same truth, the world we inhabit is loud with the glory of God. After last week's foundational doctrines, this week trained you in the appropriate response to those doctrines: worship. Worship is not optional for the Christian. It is the only sane reaction to what we now know.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Which Psalm this week resonated most with you, and why? Each Psalm captured a different aspect of God's glory in creation, the stars, the storm, the silent witness of the heavens, the voice that shakes the cedars. Sit with the one that struck you most deeply. What does your response to it reveal about what you most need to learn about God?

How does the creation testimony of these Psalms point you to Christ? Paul tells us in Colossians 1 that "by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth." The Word who spoke creation into being in Genesis 1 is the same Word who became flesh and dwelt among us. Every sunrise you have ever seen was a gift from the hand of the one who would die for you. How does that change how you receive creation today?

Where has your worship gone quiet? The Psalms this week were exuberant, shouts, songs, instruments, lifted eyes. If your worship has shrunk to a routine, what would it take to recover the energy these Psalms model?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what the heavens and the Psalms have taught you this week, and tell him what you have noticed.

Confess any distraction that has kept you from praise, and ask him to restore your wonder.

Thank Christ, through whom all things were made and hold together.

DAY 15 · WEEK 3

Psalm 65

You visit the earth and water it, God's good provision for creation

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 65 slowly, twice. This is the final psalm in our opening string of creation meditations. It is also the perfect transition: it praises God for both creation and salvation in one breath, anticipating the rest of the biblical story. Notice how the psalm moves through three movements, the forgiveness of sin, the sovereignty of God, and the blessing of creation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 65 is in many ways the perfect bridge from Unit 1 into the rest of the plan. It is one of David's psalms, and it weaves together three themes that the plan has been building: the forgiveness of sin, the awesome sovereignty of God, and the providential blessing of creation. The psalm anticipates the harvest, likely sung at a festival celebrating God's provision of rain and crops, but it sees the harvest as woven together with God's redemption of his people.

This is the kind of psalm that teaches us how to integrate doctrines we have studied separately. Creation and salvation are not two unrelated themes; they are two acts of the same God, by the same word, for the same purpose: the flourishing of his people in the world he made.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a remarkable line: "Praise is due to you, O God, in Zion, and to you shall vows be performed." Worship is presented as the natural posture of God's people.
2. Verse 3 is striking, sin is acknowledged immediately: "When iniquities prevail against me, you atone for our transgressions." Atonement before creation language.

3. The temple is described as the place of nearness: “Blessed is the one you choose and bring near, to dwell in your courts!”
4. God is addressed as the “God of our salvation” and “the hope of all the ends of the earth and of the farthest seas”, both personal and cosmic.
5. Verses 6-8 portray God establishing mountains, stilling the seas, and silencing the tumult of peoples, sovereignty over both nature and nations.
6. Verses 9-13 are a lyrical celebration of agricultural blessing, God “visits the earth,” enriches it with rain, fills the streams, prepares the grain, blesses the harvest.
7. The closing lines are pure exuberance: “The hills gird themselves with joy, the meadows clothe themselves with flocks, the valleys deck themselves with grain; they shout and sing together for joy.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 65 is a feast of biblical theology in twelve verses. It moves through three distinct movements, and each one builds on the last in a way that captures the whole sweep of Scripture.

The first movement (verses 1-4) begins where the Christian life begins: at the doorstep of God, with the question of how a sinner can come near. The opening is gentle, “Praise is due to you, O God, in Zion.” But then verse 3 takes a turn: “When iniquities prevail against me, you atone for our transgressions.” The honest acknowledgment of sin is immediately answered by God’s atoning work. Notice the order: sin acknowledged, atonement provided, then access granted. “Blessed is the one you choose and bring near, to dwell in your courts!” This is not vague religious sentiment. This is the gospel’s basic structure: sin, atonement, fellowship. David did not have the full revelation of Christ, but he had the substance, that God himself takes initiative to atone for sin and bring his people near.

The second movement (verses 5-8) zooms out to the cosmic. God is “the God of our salvation,” the “hope of all the ends of the earth and of the farthest seas.” His power establishes mountains, his strength girds itself, his voice stills the roaring of the seas and the tumult of the peoples. The horizon expands from personal forgiveness to global sovereignty. The God who atones for one believer’s sin is the same God who orders the nations and silences storms.

And then the third movement (verses 9-13), the one most often quoted, turns to the agricultural blessing of God in creation. “You visit the earth and water it.” “You crown the year with your bounty.” The streams are full, the grain is ready, the meadows are clothed

with flocks, the valleys deck themselves with grain. And the closing line is one of the most extraordinary in the Psalter: "They shout and sing together for joy." The hills, the meadows, the valleys, they sing. Creation itself rejoices in the goodness of God.

Now notice what David has done. He has not separated salvation from creation. He has not separated personal from cosmic. He has not separated divine sovereignty from the dew on the grass. All of it is woven together. The same God who atones for sin sustains the harvest. The same voice that silences the seas brings rain to the fields. The same hand that brings the worshiper near to his courts also crowns the year with bounty. This is the integrated vision of the Bible: there are not many gods doing many jobs in an unrelated universe. There is one God, doing one great work, of which creation and redemption are two faces.

This is also why a Christian's gratitude must always be comprehensive. We do not just thank God for spiritual blessings as if material blessings came from somewhere else. We do not just thank him for the harvest as if salvation were unrelated. Every good thing comes from the same hand, and the harvest itself, the dew, the rain, the meadows full of flocks, all of it bears witness to the goodness of the God who saves us.

Psalm 65 ends in such joy that even the inanimate creation is portrayed as singing. This is the sound of creation as it was meant to be, and as it will one day be again in the new heavens and new earth. The plan's first unit ends on this note: the doctrines of creation, fall, and the foreshadowing of redemption have been laid down. Now the rest of the story can unfold.

STEP 5

Connection

This is the last reading day of Unit 1, and Psalm 65 is the perfect summary. The unit began with creation in Genesis 1, God speaks, and the heavens declare. It moved through the fall in Genesis 3, and the first promise of a Redeemer. It paused on the doctrines of Scripture, the image of God, and sin. And it ranged through Psalms 8, 104, 19, 33, and 29, each praising the Creator from a different angle. Today's psalm gathers all of it together: sin acknowledged, atonement provided, sovereignty over nature and nations celebrated, the goodness of the harvest received with joy. Tomorrow's review day will help you consolidate what you have learned. And then we will move into Unit 2, the spread of sin and God's covenant with Noah, to continue the story.

STEP 6

Application

Receive God's goodness today, across every level of your life. The integrated vision of Psalm 65 is meant to shape how you live. The same God who forgives your sin gives you your daily bread. The same God who atones for your transgressions waters the fields that feed you. The same God who brings you near to his courts holds together the cosmos. Gratitude is meant to run wide.

Three practices for today. First, give honest thanks for one tangible blessing of creation, your food, the weather, a place you find beautiful, the breath in your lungs. Receive it as a gift from the hand that also forgives your sin. Second, examine where you have been treating the spiritual and material as if they came from different sources. Have you been thanking God on Sunday and forgetting his providence on Monday? Have you been crediting your salvation to God and your harvest to yourself? Bring the two back together. Third, let yourself rejoice. The psalm ends with hills singing and valleys shouting for joy. If creation rejoices in God's goodness, surely you can too. Joy is not optional for the Christian. It is the appropriate response to the kind of God this psalm describes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for one specific provision in your life this year.
- Thank him that he forgives iniquity and brings sinners near.
- Ask him to make you a joyful, thankful child today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 16 · WEEK 3

Review and Reflection

Unit 1 review, Creation & the Covenant of Works

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."
>
> GENESIS 1:1

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 1.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Genesis 1:1 is the foundational sentence of the entire Bible. Everything that follows, every covenant, every promise, every doctrine, rests on the claim it makes. There is a God. He created. He made the heavens and the earth. Before any biblical doctrine can be constructed, this single verse must be settled.

Say it aloud several times today, slowly. Notice each phrase. "In the beginning", there was a beginning, and God was there. "God created", not chaos, not gods, not accidents. God. "The heavens and the earth", everything that is, in every realm, from every angle, all of it. This one verse refutes atheism (God exists), polytheism (one God), pantheism (God is distinct from creation), dualism (one source, not two), and naturalism (the universe is not self-existent). All of it, in seven English words.

Carry this verse with you through the day. Repeat it when you encounter something beautiful in creation. Repeat it when something feels chaotic. Repeat it when you doubt the goodness of the world. The God who began everything is the God who oversees everything still.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 1 you have traveled through the first three chapters of Genesis and met the foundational doctrines on which the entire Christian faith rests. The unit began with creation itself, the God who speaks, the world he ordered, the humanity he crowned with glory and honor. You then descended into Genesis 3, where the rebellion of humanity broke what God had made good, and yet, even in that chapter, the first promise of a Redeemer was spoken.

Along the way, the plan paused three times for doctrinal reflection: on the Bible itself, the foundation of everything else; on the image of God, the basis of human dignity; and on the doctrine of sin, the diagnosis of what is wrong with the world and with each of us.

The Psalms then taught us how to respond to what we had learned. Psalm 8 marveled at the dignity God has given humanity. Psalm 104 led us through creation as ongoing providence. Psalm 19 listened to the wordless witness of the heavens. Psalm 33 contemplated the power of God's word. Psalm 29 thundered with the majesty of his voice. And Psalm 65 brought together creation, atonement, and joy in a single song.

This first unit has done foundational work. You have met the God of the Bible, Creator, holy, sovereign, near. You have met humanity as it was meant to be, image-bearing, dignified, in covenant. You have met sin, universal, deep, devastating. And you have heard the first whisper of grace, the offspring of the woman who would crush the serpent's head. Everything that comes next in the Bible builds on this foundation. The unit you are completing is the soil out of which the rest of the story grows.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the order and goodness of creation reveal about God's character?

Think about what Genesis 1 shows us through its pattern and rhythm. Creation is ordered, not chaotic, speaking to God's mind. It is good, not neutral, speaking to God's character. It is given as gift to image-bearers, speaking to God's generosity. Sit with this question: if you knew nothing about God except what Genesis 1 reveals, what would you conclude about him? Write a few sentences in your own words.

What was the nature of the covenant God made with Adam in the garden?

Revisit Genesis 2. God provided abundantly ("of every tree you may surely eat"), placed one prohibition, and made it a test of trust. This is sometimes called the covenant of works. What were the terms? What was at stake? And what does the structure tell you about the pattern of all true relationship with God, gift before command, grace before obedience?

What did the Fall change about the relationship between God and humanity?

Walk through Genesis 3 in your memory. What broke between God and Adam and Eve? What broke between Adam and Eve themselves? What broke between humanity and creation? What broke inside the human heart? The Fall was not just one bad decision; it was a comprehensive shattering. Identify three specific things that changed.

Where is the first promise of redemption in Scripture, and what does it tell us?

Genesis 3:15, sometimes called the protoevangelium, the first gospel. Read it again. What does it promise? Who is the "offspring of the woman"? What does it cost him, and what does he accomplish? And how does this single verse plant the seed of everything that will follow in Scripture? Pray through this verse, thanking God that he did not abandon humanity even in the moment of our rebellion.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what you have learned about him in these first weeks, naming one truth you want to keep.

Confess where you still resist what you have read, and ask him to keep working.

Ask him to anchor your life in the unit verse.